

■ Disfluency Effect

■ What is it?

When things are harder to read or process, people think more deeply.

For example, if text is in a slightly unusual font, you might slow down to read it. This extra effort makes you pay closer attention and remember it better.

■ History

The idea of **disfluency** comes from cognitive psychology research in the early **2000s**.

Studies showed that when students read information in slightly harder-to-read fonts, they often remembered it better than when it was in standard fonts.

This led to the concept that **a little difficulty can improve learning**—as long as it's balanced.

■ The Psychology Behind It

The brain likes shortcuts and often skims easy text without much thought. But when information is slightly harder to process, people pause, focus, and engage more deeply.

- **Too easy** → quick skimming, low memory.
- **Slightly harder** → deeper thinking, better retention.
- **Too hard** → frustration, drop-offs.

The key is balance—just enough friction to grab attention.

■ Why It Matters

Disfluency can:

- Improve memory and comprehension
- Encourage deeper reflection
- Increase engagement with content
- But if overdone, it can frustrate users or slow them down

■ How to Apply It

- **Use disfluency carefully** → only for important content.
- **Subtle variations** → unusual but readable fonts or layouts.
- **Micro-challenges** → small tasks that require focus.
- **Apply moderation** → don't overwhelm users.
- **Test results** → A/B test difficulty levels to find balance.

■ Theory in Action

- **Learning platforms** sometimes use slightly challenging quizzes or tasks to increase memory retention.
- **Print design** occasionally uses unique but readable fonts for key information to make readers slow down.

■ Final Thought

A little friction can be useful. When applied wisely, disfluency makes people pause, think, and remember—without making the experience frustrating.